

# University of Dhaka

Department of Criminology

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*Group Assignment, Part I: Movie Review*

# Selling Bullets, Bending Rules:

## Organized Crime, Corruption and the Grey Arms Market in War Dogs (2016)


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## 1. Introduction

*War Dogs* (2016) is a crime comedy-drama directed by Todd Phillips (Phillips, 2016). The main characters are played by Jonah Hill and Miles Teller, who portray two young men from Miami who become arms dealers, with Ana de Armas and Bradley Cooper in supporting roles. The film was released by Warner Bros. in August 2016. The film is based on a true story reported by the journalist Guy Lawson (Lawson, 2011, 2015). Their company, AEY, eventually wins a US Army contract worth about $300 million. The main theme revolves around how business, government and crime can become entangled with one another. The plot makes the film ideal for studying organized crime, as the criminals act in the disguise of ordinary businessmen. In this paper, we summarize the plot and analyze it using core course concepts.

The film raises a few critical questions about who is responsible when a crime occurs inside a legal system. It shows that a criminal enterprise does not necessarily need guns, gangs or secret meetings to cause serious harm. For criminology students, this makes *War Dogs* a useful case study to assess and test different definitions and theories.

## 2. Summary of the Plot

David, a struggling massage therapist in Miami, needs money because his girlfriend is pregnant. He joins his old friend Efraim, whose company bids for small military contracts online. When a weapons shipment gets stuck in Jordan, they use local fixers to deliver it to Iraq. They then meet Henry, an arms dealer on a terrorist watch list, who helps them find cheap ammunition in Albania. This deal leads AEY to win a contract to supply the Afghan army. During the deal, Efraim also tries to cut Henry out of his share, which creates tension and danger for both of them.

Later on, David discovers that the ammunition was made in China, which the contract does not allow. They hide this by repackaging the bullets and supplying them anyway. Eventually, their partnership falls apart, and the government starts an investigation. Efraim is sentenced to four years in prison, and David is sentenced to seven months of house arrest (Lawson, 2015). Throughout the film, David narrates the story, which explains how an ordinary person slowly turns into a criminal. Each step seems small, but together they lead to serious fraud. The concluding scenes also show how mistrust and greed can destroy a criminal partnership.

## 3. Conceptual Analysis

### *3.1 Key Definitions*

The United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC) defines an organized criminal group as a structured group of three or more persons that exists for a period of time and acts together to commit serious crimes for financial or other material benefit (UNODC, 2004, Art. 2). A “serious crime” means any offence punishable by at least four years in prison, and no formal hierarchy is needed. Abadinsky (2013) describes organized crime through attributes such as being non-ideological, hierarchical, having limited membership, being self-perpetuating, using violence or bribery, having specialized roles, seeking monopoly and following rules.

According to Sutherland (1940), white-collar crime is a crime committed by a respectable person in the course of their occupation or by using their position. From the state-corporate crime point of view, harm is caused by government and business working together (Kramer et al., 2002). Corruption, on the other hand, is defined as the abuse of entrusted power for private gain (Transparency International, n.d.). These definitions show how organized crime can be understood through both a broad and a narrow lens. The UN definition focuses on what a group does, while Abadinsky focuses on how a group is structured. Using both lenses helps us judge AEY more fairly in the next sections. These definitions are important because the film shows a group that is clearly criminal but does not look like a traditional gang.

### *3.2 Classification: Is AEY “Organized Crime”?*

Under the UNTOC framework, this is a case of organized crime, as Efraim, David, the financier Ralph, Henry and the Albanian suppliers form a group of more than three people who work together over the years and commit fraud and conspiracy with the objective of earning profit. It is also transnational, involving the United States, Jordan, Iraq, Albania and Afghanistan. However, the case does not match Abadinsky’s (2013) attributes, as there were no rituals or exclusive membership, no systematic use of violence, and the organization collapsed once its leaders were arrested.

Therefore, AEY is best classified as organized white-collar crime, where a legal company uses legal channels to commit organized fraud. From the outside, AEY did not look criminal, so nobody checked it. This classification is important because it challenges the conventional idea that organized crime is always violent. Many organized crime groups function through companies, contracts and bank accounts rather than weapons and threats. AEY is a classic example of how crime can hide inside ordinary business activity.

### *3.3 Models of Organized Crime*

The course introduced four main models for explaining how organized crime is structured. Table 1 summarizes how well each one explains the events of the film. Taken together, the models show that AEY was not a fixed organization but a flexible business network. Its members joined and left depending on the deal, which is typical of modern criminal enterprises. This flexibility made AEY harder to detect than a traditional criminal group.

**Table 1**

*Fit Between Organized Crime Models and the Events of War Dogs*

| Model | Core idea | Fit with the film |
|---|---|---|
| Hierarchical/bureaucratic (Cressey, 1969) | Mafia-style bureaucracy with ranks | Weak fit: AEY had no ranks or code |
| Patron–client (Albini, 1971) | Patrons give access in return for loyalty and money | Partial fit: Henry controlled access to the supplies |
| Enterprise (Smith, 1980) | Crime as a business, ranging from legal to illegal | Strong fit: AEY moved from legal bidding to fraud |
| Network (Morselli, 2009) | Brokers linking separate groups hold power | Strong fit: Efraim and Henry connected the Pentagon to the Balkan supply |

*Note.* Fit ratings are the group's assessment.

The enterprise model suits this case best, as the US government created the demand and outsourced it online (Smith, 1980). AEY drifted into illegality when the profits were high and the risk of getting caught was low. The case also fits the network model, as Efraim and Henry connected the whole business, from the Pentagon down to the Balkan supply. In this model, criminals act as nodes in a network, and those who connect different parts of it hold the most power (Morselli, 2009). On the other hand, the hierarchical model fits poorly, because AEY had no ranks, rules or code, and everything depended on Efraim.

### *3.4 Theories of Offending and Corruption*

The whole scenario can be explained through the lens of different criminological theories. The first is rational choice theory, which explains that an offender commits a crime after weighing the profit against the risk of punishment or of getting caught (Cornish & Clarke, 1986). Here, the group hid the Chinese origin of the ammunition because the profit was huge and the risk seemed small, a situation that situational crime prevention could have addressed. Another relevant theory is routine activity theory, which explains that a crime occurs when a motivated offender, a suitable target and the absence of a capable guardian converge at the same time and place (Cohen & Felson, 1979). The plot shows how a poorly monitored contract system gave the offenders a suitable target to exploit and earn huge profits from.

Strain theory explains crime as a result of economic strain: people in society share the same goals, but the opportunities to reach those goals are unequal, which creates a strain that can lead to crime (Merton, 1938). In this case, it explains David's situation, as he needed money but did not have a legitimate way to earn it, so after finding no other way, he involved himself with the group. It also reflects institutional anomie, where the desire to earn money overrides other institutional values in society (Messner & Rosenfeld, 1994). In the film, this is seen through David, who continuously lies to his family about his illegally earned money. His situation shows how financial pressure can push an ordinary person towards crime.

Sutherland's (1947) differential association theory is also very relevant here. It explains that criminal behaviour is learned through intimate relationships, and that this learning varies in frequency, duration, priority and intensity. Here, David learned criminal methods and excuses from Efraim. The characters also use techniques of neutralization to justify their actions; for example, they suggest that no one is harmed because the soldiers still receive working bullets, which is a form of denial of injury (Sykes & Matza, 1957).

Klitgaard's (1988) formula of corruption, Corruption = Monopoly + Discretion − Accountability, also describes the scenario. Here, Henry held a monopoly over the supplies, officials and fixers had the discretion to decide freely, and accountability was low during wartime. No single theory fully explains the characters' behaviour. Instead, the theories work together: strain creates the motive, differential association teaches the methods and neutralization removes the guilt. Weak oversight and corruption additionally provide the opportunity. This combination shows why both individual and structural explanations are needed.

### *3.5 The Transnational Dimension and the Licit–Illicit Nexus*

The case shows how legal and illegal markets connect across borders and nations. The ammunition starts as legal surplus in Albania, passes through brokers and companies, and arrives in Afghanistan as a legal US government purchase. The only hidden and illegal element is its origin, which makes the process similar to money laundering. Henry was on a terrorist watch list, but he used AEY's clean image to stay in the market, which clearly displays the crime–terror nexus and the link between organized crime and terrorism. Post-communist states with old stockpiles and weak institutions, such as Albania, became supply hubs.

The case also shows the limits of national law enforcement. Each nation can monitor only one part of the network, so no one can see the whole picture. International cooperation and information sharing are therefore essential parts of prevention.

## 4. Strengths and Weaknesses of the Film

The film breaks the mafia stereotype by displaying crime as a pure business with websites and invoices. It shows how a small business can exploit a government system to earn millions. It fits the enterprise and network models more closely than films such as *The Godfather*. The characters never view themselves as criminals, which is psychologically realistic. The core facts also remain true, including the contract, the repackaged Chinese ammunition and the sentences (Lawson, 2015).

However, the film's comedic elements glamorize the money and make fraud look harmless. Henry is a composite character, and the kidnapping-style threats in Albania did not happen as shown. The film focuses too much on two individuals rather than on the system. It also leaves out the Gërdec depot explosion in Albania, which killed 26 people in 2008 (Al Jazeera, 2008). Nor does it explain how a company run by a man in his early twenties passed the Pentagon's vetting. Overall, the film is a useful starting point for discussion, but it should not be treated as a documentary. Viewers need to compare it with real reports to understand the full story. Its entertainment value is high, but its educational value depends on how critically it is watched. In short, the portrayal is conceptually accurate but exaggerated in style.

## 5. Conclusion

AEY meets the UNTOC definition of an organized criminal group but does not fit the traditional mafia model. It is best explained by the enterprise and network models. The behaviour of its members is also clearly explained by rational choice theory, strain theory and differential association theory. The film is accurate in substance, but its style exaggerates the story, so viewers need a critical mindset.

In the Bangladeshi context, public procurement also relies on middlemen. Authorities should therefore vet contractors, disclose who really owns companies and check the origin of goods. As a film, *War Dogs* is entertaining as well as concerning. It showed us that organized crime can look completely normal from the outside. In future, criminologists should pay more attention to crimes hidden inside legal businesses and government contracts.

Overall, our group found that the film is a strong example of how organized crime is changing. Modern organized crime does not always look like the mafia; it can look like a small company with a laptop and a government contract. Studying this film helped us connect the theories from our course to a real case.

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